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DEALING WITH IT: The UPA-Left Committee

group on the comrades. However, and here is the catch, the only Congressmen on the panel are the ones in the government. Congress spokesmen insist that the panel is a political and not a Government set-up, but the UPA is represented only by Cabinet ministers. Sonia's Political Secretary Ahmad Patel, who was a vital part of the troubleshooting with the Left, is not on board. Patel's exclusion is significant as his views are closely associated with those of the Congress chief.

Clearly, Sonia is distancing both herself and her party from the mean-

THE TALKING SHOP

If its first meeting is any indication, the UPA-Left Committee is unlikely to break the deadlock. It just buys the Government time.

As committees go, the UPA-Left panel seems to be living up to its unstated brief: a mechanism to buy time for the Government rather than come up with any radical breakthrough on the impasse over the Indo-US nuclear deal. When both the prime minister and the Left refused to blink, a joint committee was set up to save the Government and a crisis was blown over. Status quo continued. The Left kept up its rhetoric of confrontation. Congress chief Sonia Gandhi too stuck to her support of the Prime Minister, writing an editorial in the party mouthpiece claiming that the deal was "in the long-term interests of the nation". The only difference now is that the warring coalition partners have a safety net in place. The pretence of a mechanism has given them the much needed excuse not to call off the alliance just yet. Buying time—that in a nutshell is all that the panel is expected to achieve.

Which is perhaps why the first meeting did nothing more than chalk out the rules of the masquerade. As convener, it was Congress trou-

bleshooter Pranab Mukherjee who set down the broad framework of the discussion—the impact of the Hyde Act on the 123 Agreement, self-reliance in the nuclear sector and the deal's implications on India's foreign policy. The Left leaders say they are satisfied with this framework for a structured discussion. Mukherjee had prepared a note countering all the objections raised by the Left. The Communists will give their reply to this at the next meet. At the meeting it was clearly all work and no play. Union Railway Minister Lalu Prasad's attempts to lighten the atmosphere through questions like why was the Left showing the red flag were met with a terse reply that when accidents took place, flags were raised.

An interesting nuance is the composition of the panel. As Mukherjee said at the beginning of the meeting after various Congress leaders failed to move the Left, it was decided to bring the UPA allies into the ambit of talks. What he left unsaid was that with this move, the Congress was hoping that the allies would work as a pressure

dering of the committee—a fact that did not go down well with CP(M) supremo Prakash Karat, who was initially not keen to be part of the panel either. There is a reason for this. The Congress feels that the Government cannot back out of the deal now. With the Left refusing to soften its stand, mid-term polls seem inevitable. Hence it makes political sense for the Congress to distance itself from any acrimony that the panel may throw up between the two allies. Says a Cabinet minister, "The Communists do not matter anywhere except two states. Our main target is BJP." Two crucial questions remain: Will the Government give in to the Left and stop "operationalising" the agreement until the UPA-Left panel gives its findings? Mukherjee says, "Talks may fail and talks may succeed. But talks do not mean operationalising." And will the Government be bound by the findings of the joint panel? "When we come to a final decision, we will take the Left's concerns into account," says Congress Minister Kapil Sibal. However, one thing that everyone agrees on is that no one is ready for a mid-term poll. For now, the secular combine wants to focus on defeating the BJP in the Gujarat polls due in December. With both sides refusing to relent, it looks as if the minutes of the UPA-Left panel are going to stretch into months.

by Priya Sahgal